

Perplexity: Research with Sources

Move from “I found an answer” to “I can show and verify the evidence.”

Ask sharper questions

Trace citations

Compare documents

Build Spaces

Today's mission

Investigate a useful question, challenge the evidence, and create a source-backed mini-brief.

A confident answer without evidence starts the mystery.

1. The question

Maya, a teacher, asks: "Does screen time always harm learning?" An AI gives a polished answer.

2. The uncomfortable pause

Which studies? How recent? Which ages? What do experts disagree about?

3. The detective move

Maya needs an answer she can inspect, challenge, explain, and responsibly share.

Class question: Would you use an answer in a meeting if you could not show where it came from?

Perplexity behaves like search, reading, and conversation in one loop.

1

Search

Find current web evidence instead of relying only on remembered training data.

2

Read

Synthesize information from multiple sources into a direct answer.

3

Talk

Continue with follow-up questions inside the same Thread.

Answer engine

Visible citations

Current web research

Follow-up investigation

Four engineers built an answer engine to make search deliver direct, cited answers.

1

Aravind Srinivas

AI research and leadership

2

Denis Yarats

AI research and systems

3

Johnny Ho

Engineering and strategy

4

Andy Konwinski

Data platforms and infrastructure

Founded: August 2022 in San Francisco. **The frustration:** traditional search often makes people hunt through links before understanding the answer.

● ● ● FREE TOOLKIT

The free plan is enough to learn the essential research habits.

Core Search

Ask questions and receive cited answers.

5 Pro Searches/day

Use carefully for complex research.

3 file uploads

Select documents intentionally.

Threads

Ask connected follow-ups.

Saved work

Return to useful research.

Discover

Explore current topics and stories.

Spaces

Organize reusable project research.

Limited Research

Try deeper, longer reports.

Ask fewer, sharper questions

Limits vary and may change

A strong Perplexity session follows six visible moves.

1

Ask

Make the question precise.

2

Select

Choose useful source types.

3

Read

Scan the answer and claims.

4

Trace

Open the citations.

5

Follow

Probe gaps and disagreements.

6

Save

Store the useful trail.

The answer is only step three. Verification is where research becomes trustworthy.

Sample answer

Short movement breaks can improve attention during classroom learning. 1

The effect varies by age, activity type, and lesson design. 2

The small source numbers are the most important part of the answer.

Open it

Does the source support the exact claim?

Date it

Is it recent enough for this question?

Judge it

Who wrote it, and why?

Better research prompts specify question, context, evidence, and output.

Question

What must be answered?

Context

Who is it for, and why?

Evidence

What sources and dates matter?

Output

How should the result look?

TEST IT For school leaders in Nepal, explain three evidence-based ways to reduce teacher administrative workload. Use sources from 2024 onward, note disagreements, and end with a five-point action list.

One topic can reveal five different Perplexity capabilities.

CURRENT What are the latest recommendations on teaching AI literacy in schools? Cite sources and show publication dates.

COMPARE Compare two viewpoints on homework effectiveness. Where do the sources disagree?

ACADEMIC Find recent academic evidence on retrieval practice. Explain it for a beginner teacher.

FOLLOW-UP Which claim in your answer has the weakest evidence? Explain why.

SYNTHESIZE Turn the strongest findings into a 150-word staff briefing with citations.

Lab rule

After every answer, inspect at least two citations. Record one source you trust and one you reject.

Perplexity wins when the task begins with “find and verify.”

Task	Best first choice	Why
Current facts with citations	Perplexity	Direct synthesis with visible web sources
Brainstorming and drafting	ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini	Flexible creation and transformation
Learning from a fixed trusted source pack	NotebookLM	Grounded in documents you select
Finding and browsing websites yourself	Google / Bing	Maximum control over link discovery
Reusable research room	Perplexity Space	Threads, sources, instructions, and sharing

There is no universal best AI tool. Choose the tool that matches the moment in your knowledge journey.

Source selection changes what kind of evidence enters the answer.



SOURCE TEST Answer the same question using web sources, then academic sources. What changed in the claims, language, detail, and confidence?

Which source would you open first?

Question: "What are effective ways to improve student attendance?"

A 2025 education ministry report

An anonymous social post

A news headline with no linked study

A recent systematic review

Choose a source and explain your reasoning before revealing the feedback.

Use the DART test

- **Date:** recent enough?
- **Author:** qualified and identifiable?
- **Reason:** inform, sell, persuade, entertain?
- **Trace:** can you find the original evidence?

Follow-up questions turn a search into an investigation.

Q1

Start

What does the evidence say?

Q2

Compare

Which sources disagree?

Q3

Challenge

What is missing?

Q4

Translate

Explain for my audience.

Q5

Conclude

Create a cautious conclusion.

The best follow-up is often not “tell me more.” It is “show me where the evidence is weak.”

Three careful uploads can still produce a powerful comparison.

A

School policy

What must happen?

B

Research report

What evidence supports it?

C

Meeting notes

What is happening locally?

CROSS-DOCUMENT PROMPT Using only the attached documents, create a table of agreements, contradictions, and unanswered questions. Cite the document name for every row. Do not use the web.

Remove private data first

Name files clearly

Ask for document-level citations

A Space is a reusable research room, not just a folder.

Threads

Questions and investigations

Sources

Web, academic, files, and more

Grade 8 Climate Project

Every new Thread begins with the same research rules and project context.

Instructions

Evidence and answer rules

People

Share and collaborate

Custom instructions make the Space behave like a careful research assistant.

SPACE INSTRUCTIONS

You support teachers at a secondary school in Nepal. Prefer sources from governments, universities, and recognized organizations. Always show publication dates. Separate evidence from suggestions. Use simple English and flag uncertainty.

Three instruction layers

1. **Identity:** who the Space supports
2. **Evidence rules:** preferred sources, dates, exclusions
3. **Answer style:** tone, length, language, format

Build one Space

Add two Threads

QUESTION

How can schools reduce teacher administrative workload?

AUDIENCE

school leaders in Nepal

EVIDENCE

credible sources from 2024 onward

OUTPUT

a five-point action list

EXTRA RULES

Note disagreements, cite every major claim, and flag uncertainty.

Build prompt

Copy prompt

Your Perplexity research brief

Research question: How can schools reduce teacher administrative workload?

Context and audience: Prepare this for school leaders in Nepal.

Evidence requirements: Use credible sources from 2024 onward. Show publication dates and cite every major factual claim.

Output: Produce a five-point action list.

Additional rules: Note disagreements, cite every major claim, and flag uncertainty.

Before concluding:

1. Identify important disagreements between sources.
2. Tell me which claim has the weakest evidence.
3. Separate evidence from suggestions.
4. State what remains uncertain.
5. List the three strongest sources and explain why they are credible.

Perplexity can still be wrong, incomplete, or poorly sourced.

Claim

Is it specific enough to verify?

Citation

Does the source support that exact claim?

Source

Is it credible for this topic?

Date

Is it recent enough?

Balance

Are important disagreements missing?

Privacy

Did you upload sensitive information?

Never paste private student, staff, medical, financial, or confidential data into a public AI tool.

The session alternates story, demo, experiment, and creation.

00:00–00:25 **Mystery + origin** Understand answer engines and why evidence matters.

01:05–01:15 **Break** Reset.

02:00–02:40 **Files + Spaces** Compare documents and build one reusable Space.

02:50–03:35 **Capstone** Create a source-backed mini-brief in pairs.

00:25–01:05 **Search + citations** Run prompts; open, judge, and reject weak sources.

01:15–02:00 **Prompt lab** Test current, compare, academic, follow-up, and synthesis prompts.

02:40–02:50 **Break** Reset.

03:35–04:00 **Share + reflect** Explain a finding, citation, and limitation.

Learners build a source-backed brief from web evidence and documents.

1

Question

One clear, useful decision

2

Evidence

At least four credible sources

3

Documents

Compare up to three selected files

4

Brief

250 words with citations

5

Reflection

One limitation and next check

STARTER

Research one realistic improvement for our school or workplace. Explain the evidence, compare it with our uploaded documents, cite every major claim, and state what remains uncertain.

The goal is not faster answers. It is faster, inspectable understanding.

Ask a sharper question, trace the evidence, verify before trusting, and share conclusions with honest limits.

Celebrate

Print / Save PDF

Exit ticket

1. Name one citation you trust.
2. Name one citation you rejected.
3. Explain why you made each decision.
4. State one thing you still need to verify.